

Figure 9.4
The Need to Belong: One Reason for Adolescent Conformity
Because adolescents have a strong need to belong–to be part of a friendship group–they often show a high level of conformity adopting whatever styles of dress, grooming, and speech are popular among their friends.

and acquaintances. Girls tend to have somewhat larger networks than boys, and these networks tend to become smaller and more exclusive as adolescents grow older (Urberg et al., 1995)—a trend that continues throughout life (e.g., Fung, Carstensen, & Lutz, in press).

One motive for forming friendships during adolescence seems to be the developing *need to belong*—the need to have frequent positive interactions within ongoing relationships. This need strengthens during early adolescence and leads many preteens and teenagers to reject parental influence and to identify with their peers. Thus, they adopt the dress, style of speech, and overall style of their chosen peer group, sometimes to the point where parents worry that their offspring have entirely surrendered their unique identity. Within a few years, however, this tendency subsides, and teenagers begin to conform less and less to their peer group.

Friendships and social success also play an important role in another key aspect of social development during adolescence—the quest for a *personal identity*. This process is a key element in a famous theory of psychosocial development proposed by Erik Erikson (1950, 1987), a theory well worthy of a closer look.

Erikson's Eight Stages of Life

Erikson's theory deals with development across the entire life span, so we could have introduced it in Chapter 8. But adolescence is in some ways a bridge between childhood and adulthood, so it makes sense to examine the theory here; we can look back to topics we covered previously and ahead to ones we'll discuss later.

Erikson's theory is, like Piaget's, a *stage* theory: It suggests that all human beings pass through specific stages or phases of development. In contrast to Piaget's theory, however, Erikson's is concerned primarily with social rather than cognitive development. Erikson believed that each stage of life is marked by a specific crisis or conflict between competing tendencies. Only if individuals negotiate each of these hurdles successfully can they continue to develop in a normal, healthy manner.

The stages in Erikson's theory are summarized in Table 9.1. The first four occur during childhood; one takes place during adolescence; and the final three occur during our adult years. The initial stage, which occurs during the first year of life, centers on the crisis of *trust versus mistrust*. Infants must trust others to satisfy their needs. If these needs are not met, infants fail to develop feelings of trust in others and remain forever suspicious and wary.

Table 9.1 Erikson's Eight Stages of Psychosocial Development

CRISIS/PHASE	DESCRIPTION
Trust versus mistrust	Infants learn either to trust the environment (if needs are met) or to mistrust it.
Autonomy versus shame and doubt	Toddlers acquire self-confidence if they learn to regulate their bodies and act independently. If they fail or are labeled as inadequate, they experience shame and doubt.
Initiative versus guilt	Preschoolers (aged 3–5) acquire new physical and mental skills but must also learn to control their impulses. Unless a good balance is struck, they become either unruly or too inhibited.
Industry versus inferiority	Children (aged 6–11) acquire many skills and competencies. If they take pride in these, they acquire high self-esteem. If they compare themselves unfavorably with others, they may develop low self-esteem.
Identity versus role confusion	Adolescents must integrate various roles into a consistent self-identity. If they fail to do so, they may experience confusion over who they are.
Intimacy versus isolation	Young adults must develop the ability to form deep, intimate relationships with others. If they do not, they may become socially or emotionally isolated.
Generativity versus self-absorption	Adults must take an active interest in helping and guiding younger persons. If they do not, they may become preoccupied with purely selfish needs.
Integrity versus despair	In the closing decades of life, individuals ask themselves whether their lives had any meaning. If they can answer yes, they attain a sense of integrity. If they answer no, they experience despair.

The next crisis occurs during the second year of life and involves *autonomy versus shame and doubt*. During this time, toddlers are learning to regulate their own bodies and to act in independent ways. If they succeed in these tasks, they develop a sense of autonomy. But if they fail, or if they are labeled as inadequate by the persons who care for them, they may experience shame and may doubt their abilities to interact effectively with the external world.

The third stage unfolds during the preschool years, between the ages of three and five. The crisis at this time involves what Erikson terms *initiative versus guilt*. During these years, children are acquiring many new physical and mental skills. Simultaneously, however, they must develop the capacity to control their impulses, some of which lead to unacceptable behavior. If they strike the right balance between feelings of initiative and feelings of guilt, all is well. However, if initiative overwhelms guilt, children may become too unruly for their own good; if guilt overwhelms initiative, they may become too inhibited.

The fourth and final stage of childhood occurs during the early school years, when children are between six and eleven or twelve years of age. This stage involves the crisis of *industry versus inferiority*. During these years, children learn to make things, use tools, and acquire many of the skills necessary for adult life. Children who successfully acquire these skills form a sense of their own competence; those who do not may compare themselves unfavorably with others and suffer from low self-esteem.

Now we come to the crucial stage in Erikson's theory for this discussion of adolescence: the crisis of *identity versus role confusion*. At this time of life, teenagers ask themselves, "Who am I?" "What am I *really* like?" "What do I want to become?" In other words, they seek to establish a clear *self-identity*—to understand their own unique traits and what is really of central importance to them. These, of course, are questions individuals ask themselves at many points in life. According to Erikson, though, during adolescence it is crucial that these questions be answered effectively. If they are not, individuals may drift, uncertain of where they want to go or what they wish to accomplish.

Adolescents adopt many different strategies to help them resolve their own personal identity crises. They try out many different roles—the good girl/boy, the rebel, the dutiful daughter/son, the athlete, the supercool operator—and join many different social groups. They consider many possible *social selves*—different kinds of persons they might potentially become (Markus & Nurius, 1986). Out of these experiences they gradually piece together a cognitive framework for understanding themselves—a *self-schema*. Once formed, this framework remains fairly constant and serves as a guide for adolescents in many contexts.

Many psychologists other than Erikson have focused on the importance of forming a clear personal identity (e.g., Noller, 1994). For instance, Marcia (1991) suggests that adolescents can be categorized in terms of whether they have explored alternative selves and whether they have actually chosen one. These two dimensions yield four possible patterns: adolescents who have gone through their identity crisis and made a commitment to one clear alternative (they are described as showing *identity achievement*); adolescents who are still searching for an identity (*identity moratorium*); adolescents who have chosen an identity suggested to them by their parents or other authority figures (*identity foreclosure*); and adolescents who haven't begun the process (identity diffusion). Marcia (1991) suggests that resolving the identity crisis is an important aspect of development during adolescence, and that completing this task helps individuals to plan their adult lives and, ultimately, to attain personal happiness (Diener & Suh, 1997).

The remaining three stages in Erikson's theory (refer to Table 9.1) relate to crises we face as adults. We'll return to them in our later discussions of adult development.

Living in Two Worlds: Identity Formation among Bicultural Adolescents

What about adolescents whose parents are immigrants or whose parents come from two different ethnic or cultural groups? Do they experience special problems in forming a clear identity? Growing research on this issue suggests that they do. After all, such children must understand not merely one culture and their place in it, but *two* cultures, which may differ in many respects. How do they cope with this situation? One possibility is that they achieve separate identities in both cultures, then alternate between these depending on the social situation; this is known as the *alternation model*. So, for instance, children with one African American parent and one European parent, or with one Hispanic parent and one European parent, may act differently depending on whether they are interacting with relatives or friends from each group.

Another pattern is known as **identity fusion**. Here, the children combine the different cultural identities into one. There is a growing tendency for people in the United States, where the number of biracial or multiracial children is increasing rapidly, to do this. Such adolescents describe themselves not as belonging to either group but as "biracial" or of "mixed race." A third pattern is for such adolescents to reject one of their cultural heritages and to identify entirely with the other. This pattern is especially likely in children who recognize that adopting a social identity linked to one of the two cultures may lead to discrimination against them—and therefore choose the other.

Identity Fusion: A pattern in which bicultural or multicultural children combine their different cultural identities into one.